

Intel maintained backwards compatibility between the recent two generations of platforms with their processors. So both, 12th Gen and 13th Gen processors are compatible with Z690 and Z790 motherboards. The only difference is the way PCIe lanes are segmented. The Z790 motherboards ship with 20 PCIe 4.0 lanes from the CPU and 8 PCIe 3.0 lanes from the chipset. Essentially, more fast lanes are available on Z790 motherboards that allow manufacturers to play around with a lot more storage and connectivity options. The Raptor Lake processors also have double the efficiency cores, which needs a bit more power from the motherboard, and that's also been incorporated onto the Z790 designs.

Winner: ASUS ROG MAXIMUS Z790 EXTREME

An overclocker's delight, the ASUS ROG MAXIMUS Z790 EXTREME is



GIGABYTE Z790 AORUS MASTER

Price: ₹54,999

loaded to the brim with features. There are tonnes of options to tweak every parameter, helping get the absolute most out of your processor. The price is quite high but the feature set is practically unmatched by any of the other boards that came to us. It has 10 GbE port, validation with very high speed memory kits, teamed VRM circuit, a detailed BIOS with exhaustive set of options and more. Everything about the board, from the feature set to the build

quality to the vast array of connectivity options, all boast of the best that the platform has to offer and for that, it wins this year's Zero1 Award.

1st Runner-up: GIGABYTE Z790 AORUS MASTER

The MASTER series of motherboards from AORUS make for one of the top-most motherboards from GIGABYTE. It boasts of a 20+1+2 power phase design for the VRM making it excellent for providing a clean and steady source of power for the most powerful processors from the Intel 13th Gen lineup. There is a tonne of aluminium shielding across the surface and a pretty dense set of cooling fins over the VRM circuitry. AORUS has done a great job of balancing out the connectivity options. In our testing, the board was just a smidge behind the winner. The competition is intensely close as usual and it simply comes down to how efficiently the different components speak to each other.

Best Buy: MSI MAG Z790 TOMAHAWK WIFI DDR4

Opting for DDR5 is still an expensive venture. It will spike your PC build cost by at least 6-10K. Getting a Z790 motherboard that offers most of the features that the DDR5 boards have without breaking the bank is what nets the MSI MAG Z790 TOMAHAWK WIFI DDR4 board the Best Buy Award this year. You still get PCIe 5.0 lanes from the CPU, the audio CODEC is top notch and there's a 2.5 GbE port. For someone hoping to get onto the Z790 platform, this is a great board to buy.

— Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

DIGIT BEST BUY WINNER-2022



MSI MAG Z790 TOMAHAWK WIFI DDR4

Price: ₹30,250

Mainstream Intel Z790 Motherboards

A worthy companion for 13th Gen CPUs



ASUS ROG MAXIMUS Z790 EXTREME

Price: ₹98,999